CONVENIENCE, MYSTIQUE AND UNSUPPORTED AUTHORITY
A CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK FOR EVIDENCE-SENSITIVE APPRAISAL OF CLAIMS

Max Barrass, MISM

Conceptual working paper • Version 4.0 • 12 November 2026

Convenience–Mystique–Fiducial (CMF) framework

ABSTRACT

Compelling claims can gain acceptance for reasons other than their evidential support. This paper develops the Convenience–Mystique–Fiducial (CMF) framework into a research programme for examining three potentially influential features: anticipated relief from effort or unwanted consequences, narrative appeal, and asserted authority whose relevant basis is not available for independent inspection. The central proposition is conditional: these features may encourage acceptance or transmission by reducing evidence-seeking, with scarce attention and weak accountability as candidate moderators for future testing. They are neither necessary nor sufficient indicators of falsehood. A convenient claim can be true, an engaging explanation can improve understanding, and reliance on qualified experts is often rational. The framework therefore separates persuasion cues, verification behaviour, independently assessed evidential support and downstream decisions. Existing research supplies component-level plausibility, not validation of the combined model. A bounded, estimable statistical specification is offered as a candidate rather than a universal law. The proposed programme combines construct development, controlled experiments, checklist evaluation and external validation. A practical appraisal procedure translates the theory into proportionate questions without diagnosing dishonesty or replacing substantive expertise. The intended contribution is a falsifiable synthesis and a disciplined decision aid, not a machine for detecting truth.

Keywords: claim appraisal; epistemic vigilance; persuasion; cognitive effort; narrative transportation; source credibility; misinformation; verification.

Status. This paper develops a testable conceptual model. It reports no original participant data, estimates, validated diagnostic thresholds or proven theorem. Section 9 outlines a proposed validation programme; a detailed protocol would need to be developed and preregistered before confirmatory data collection.

---

1. THE PROBLEM AND THE PROPOSED CONTRIBUTION

A proposition may be accepted because it is well supported. It may also be accepted because it promises an easy resolution, tells an attractive story or arrives with confident assertions of expertise. These reasons sometimes coincide. The practical difficulty is not that every persuasive claim is suspect, but that its psychological appeal can be mistaken for the evidence supporting it.

The concern motivating CMF is that organisations and individuals may substitute comfort, glamour and confidence for checking. An appealing proposal can move faster than its justification. Investigating that concern requires precise claims, independent measurements and explicit opportunities for failure. Rhetorical force cannot stand in for a demonstrated mechanism.

The present paper asks: under what conditions do convenience, mystique and unsupported authority alter verification and acceptance, and can a proportionate appraisal procedure improve decisions? It does not ask whether a reader can infer truth directly from presentation style. It distinguishes accepting a proposition, undertaking an action, passing a claim to others and deferring to a source. These are separate outcomes with different costs and social incentives.

The proposed contribution is integrative and procedural. The constructs have substantial antecedents in psychology, philosophy and communication research. No claim is made that CMF discovers cognitive effort avoidance, narrative persuasion, source credibility or motivated reasoning. Its potential value is to organise their interaction around a practical sequence: notice appeal, identify what is being claimed, inspect the evidential route and make a decision proportional to consequences. Whether the synthesis adds value over existing constructs or a simpler verification checklist is an empirical question.

2. INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATIONS AND BOUNDARIES

2.1 Effort, convenience and fluency

Kool et al. (2010) provide experimental evidence that people can avoid cognitively demanding tasks. That supports investigating effort costs; it does not establish that humans invariably prefer convenient falsehoods to difficult truths. Effort avoidance may be adaptive when effort is costly and unlikely to improve the decision.

Processing fluency concerns the experienced ease of processing information. Alter and Oppenheimer (2009) review its role in metacognitive judgments. Fluency is not identical to CMF convenience: a clearly written but demanding proposal can be fluent without offering an easy outcome, while a difficult-to-read promise can still offer emotional relief. Hassan and Barber (2021) found increased truth ratings with repeated exposure to trivia claims, with diminishing gains. That result does not uniquely establish fluency as the mechanism. Repetition and readability should be measured or controlled rather than silently folded into convenience. The distinction matters for intervention design. Making evidence more accessible may improve scrutiny rather than weaken it.

Kunda's (1990) account of motivated reasoning provides a further distinction. People may recruit reasoning in service of desired conclusions, subject to constraints on plausible justification. Desired outcome, anticipated effort and perceptual ease are related possibilities, not interchangeable variables. The CMF programme should initially measure them separately.

2.2 Narrative appeal

Green and Brock (2000) investigate transportation into narratives and effects on beliefs. This makes narrative involvement a plausible pathway for influence, but neither the presence of a story nor the experience of transportation establishes deception. Narrative can communicate accurate causal structure, make evidence memorable and help a reader understand unfamiliar consequences.

Mystique can encompass intrigue, glamour, drama, secrecy and technological fashion. A single undifferentiated rating would be difficult to interpret. This paper uses mystique as an umbrella term while distinguishing narrative absorption from prestige language and secrecy claims. The first confirmatory study should manipulate one clearly specified feature; later studies can determine whether these facets share a useful common factor.

2.3 Authority, testimony and warranted reliance

Petty, Cacioppo and Goldman (1981) examined how personal relevance changes the influence of argument quality and source expertise. Hoogeveen et al. (2022) found that source attribution affected credibility judgments of meaningless claims across countries. These findings make source cues relevant, without implying that expertise is worthless or that reliance on testimony is inherently irrational.

Most people cannot personally reproduce every finding on which they rely. Appropriate deference depends on relevant competence, an inspectable basis for claims, independent corroboration, conflicts and institutional correction mechanisms. CMF targets the substitution of asserted authority for an adequate route to evidence, not expertise itself. An expert who cannot disclose confidential evidence may warrant a qualified decision or additional safeguards rather than an accusation of dishonesty.

In the Convenience–Mystique–Fiducial (CMF) framework, the fiducial component concerns unsupported authority: reliance on asserted authority or trust in place of an adequate basis for evaluating a claim. A study would measure observable authority cues (A) separately from evidential support (E); whether reliance is unsupported depends on their relation. The phrase “trust me” is an informal illustration, not a measurement instrument.

2.4 Epistemic vigilance and receptivity

Sperber et al. (2010) describe mechanisms involved in evaluating communicated information and its sources. This is an important corrective to a wholly passive picture of audiences: people already use safeguards, albeit imperfectly and differently across settings.

Pennycook et al. (2015) studied receptivity to pseudo-profound bullshit, including judgments of statements constructed to sound profound. That task concerns a particular form of vacuity. It is not equivalent to detecting scams, assessing a business case or determining the truth of a scientific claim. Frankfurt’s (2005) philosophical distinction between lying and indifference to truth is also useful, but intent or indifference cannot be reliably inferred from polished language alone. In this paper, “unsupported,” “false,” “vacuous” and “deceptive” are kept separate.

Accuracy-prompt research provides a reason to test whether directing attention to accuracy can improve sharing quality and discernment (Pennycook et al., 2021). Transfer cannot be assumed. Littrell et al. (2024) found that explanatory reflection reduced receptivity to pseudo-profound bullshit but not the scientific bullshit or politically neutral fake-news materials they tested. An intervention that succeeds in one genre can fail in another. CMF must earn its practical claims separately in each intended context.

3. SCOPE AND CONSTRUCT DEFINITIONS

The unit of analysis is a **claim–recipient–decision encounter**. A claim may contain several propositions, so appraisal begins by specifying the proposition and requested decision. “This product uses AI” and “this product will halve our costs within three months” require different evidence. Where a communication bundles claims, the central consequential claim is rated separately from supporting claims.

Convenience (C) is the recipient’s anticipated reduction in effort, discomfort or unwanted consequences associated with accepting the claim or complying with it, relative to plausible alternatives. Effort relief and emotional relief are initially separate subscales. Convenience is not actual benefit, objective truth or the amount of evidence supplied. A promise of easy recovery after a data loss can be highly convenient even if the recovery is impossible.

Mystique (M) is the appeal associated with a claim’s dramatic, exceptional, glamorous or intrigue-laden presentation. The initial operational focus is narrative involvement, measured separately from readability, familiarity and perceived relevance. A technically accurate account can score high. The research question concerns what the presentation does to appraisal, not whether attractive stories are invalid.

Authority cue (A) is the degree to which confidence, status or privileged access is offered as a reason to accept a proposition. This observable communication feature is coded separately from the strength and accessibility of its evidential basis. Unsupported authority, the fiducial component defined in section 2.3, concerns reliance on such cues without an adequate evidential route; it is not defined by a high A score alone. A proposed experiment would vary the authority assertion while holding evidence and access constant within matched comparisons. A transparent-expertise benchmark would distinguish asserted authority from warranted reliance. A is not a person’s competence score and must not encode the assessor’s dislike of the source.

Verification (V) is observable engagement with evidence relevant to the decision: opening a source, inspecting methods, requesting a missing basis, checking an independent channel or comparing a competing account. Time spent reading is insufficient by itself. Verification quality requires a rubric that distinguishes a meaningful check from activity that merely repeats the original assertion.

Acceptance (Y) is a measured judgment or decision specified in advance: judged probability of a claim, endorsement, intended action or an actual consequential choice

within an ethical study. Sharing (S) is measured separately; people may share for amusement, identity or criticism without believing a claim.

Evidence status (E) is assessed independently of C, M and A, using raters blinded to cue condition where feasible. Depending on the domain, it may comprise corroboration, methodological quality, relevance, reproducibility and the strength of the inference to the specific claim. A prespecified coding rubric should document disagreement and unresolved evidence. Evidence quality is not identical to truth: truth labels are used only when defensible, and an uncertain forecast should not be labelled false merely because it is not yet verified.

Context (Z) includes domain knowledge, stakes, prior belief, time pressure, accountability, incentives, literacy and trust history. These may moderate effects or explain apparent associations. Recipient-specific convenience means that identical text need not have an identical C value across people.

4. MECHANISMS AND RIVAL EXPLANATIONS

The candidate pathway is: a claim offers relief or appeal; the recipient experiences lower motivation to inspect its evidential basis; acceptance or transmission increases despite unchanged evidence. Unsupported authority may further license deference. This is a hypothesised pathway, not the sole route from cues to behaviour.

An alternative is direct relevance: an attractive message may simply capture attention, increasing both reading and verification. A second alternative is rational delegation: a credible source lowers the expected benefit of checking because it genuinely provides a reliable signal. A third is comprehension: better presentation can make sound evidence easier to evaluate. A fourth is motivated reasoning: a pre-existing preference may independently increase both perceived convenience and acceptance. Boudry and Braeckman (2012) describe self-validating belief systems and defensive reinterpretation. Their sense of convenience concerns resistance to disconfirmation, rather than low processing effort. This suggests a further possibility: a recipient may scrutinise extensively but selectively, protecting a preferred claim rather than testing it. CMF must measure the quality and direction of scrutiny as well as its presence. A fifth is resource constraint: people may skip checks because they lack time or access, rather than because the communication changes their motivation.

These alternatives yield competing predictions. If appeal increases acceptance of well-supported claims while preserving discrimination between strong and weak evidence, the effect is not an epistemic failure. If authority effects disappear when relevant qualifications and evidence are held constant, a broad “trust me” explanation is weakened. If C, M and A add no predictive information beyond prior belief, familiarity, fluency and source credibility, CMF may be a useful communication mnemonic but not a distinct explanatory model.

Additional scrutiny does not guarantee that true claims will be accepted or false claims rejected. True claims can fail an impractical test, lack affordable replication or be rejected by biased institutions. False claims can survive repeated scrutiny through weak tests or motivated interpretation. The correct question is whether a feasible test discriminates relevant possibilities, not whether a proponent can withstand arbitrary obstacles.

5. FORMALISATION WITHOUT MATHEMATICAL OVERCLAIMING

5.1 Constraints on a defensible mathematical model

A mathematical expression intended to represent a probability must remain between zero and one over its specified domain. Model behaviour must agree with the interpretation of its inputs, and boundary cases must be defined. A predicted probability is distinct from a statistical p-value. These requirements do not establish that a model is empirically adequate: even a mathematically valid specification may fail to explain or predict observations.

Numerical scales, weights and diagnostic thresholds require empirical calibration rather than intuitive assignment. The specification below treats independently assessed evidence as a predictor of a recipient’s response, not as an answer to a truth-detection problem. Its coefficients must be estimated from observations. It provides an illustrative starting model for acceptance, not a complete confirmatory analysis plan for every hypothesis.

5.2 An estimable candidate

For a binary acceptance outcome, an illustrative main-effects candidate is:

$$\begin{aligned} &\mathit{logit}\ \ Pr(Y_{ij}=1) = \beta_0 + \beta_C C_{ij} + \beta_M M_{ij} + \beta_A A_{ij} + \beta_E E_{ij} \\ &+\ \gamma^T Z_{ij} + u_i + v_j . \end{aligned}$$

Here i indexes recipients and j indexes claims. The probability on the left is conditional on the displayed predictors and random intercepts u_i and v_j for recipients and claims. Evidence strength E_{ij} describes the evidence assigned or presented to recipient i for claim j; it is held constant within matched cue comparisons but may vary across randomised evidence conditions. Z_{ij} is a vector of prespecified contextual predictors, and $\gamma^T Z_{ij}$ is their weighted contribution. The logistic transformation bounds predicted probabilities. Predictors must be defined before analysis and standardised using training data where appropriate. Coefficients are unknown and must not be assigned by intuition. An ordinal or continuous model may be preferable for a graded judgment outcome.

This specification is not a universal truth formula. It predicts a specified response in a specified population under stated conditions. Evidence strength is independently coded and is not a disguised "bullshit score." Pairwise cue interactions (C × M, C × A and M × A) and higher-order extensions are exploratory candidates, not established effects or part of the displayed starting model. Their evaluation requires adequate data, explicit analysis plans and separation from confirmatory tests. A hypothesis-specific confirmatory model may require a prespecified interaction, such as the prompt × evidence-quality contrast needed to test evidence discrimination in H4.

The displayed acceptance model illustrates one outcome only. H1 and H2 require a separate model of verification quality as their primary endpoint; H3 requires a prespecified authority-condition contrast among weak-evidence claims. Causal tests must use randomised cue assignments, not treat post-treatment perception ratings as randomised exposures. Associations with measured C, M and A do not by themselves establish causation. Mediation through verification requires stronger assumptions or an additional intervention on the checking opportunity. A future protocol should distinguish prespecified total cue effects from exploratory mediation analyses.

5.3 Decision support is not score display

A probability estimated in one corpus should not be displayed as a universal risk score. Before any deployment, calibration, discrimination, uncertainty, subgroup performance and decision consequences must be assessed on held-out settings. A high cue score is not a finding that the claim is false or that its author is dishonest. A checklist may be preferable to a fitted score because it exposes missing information rather than hiding judgments in a composite number.

6. FALSIFIABLE PROPOSITIONS

H1 — Effort relief. With stakes, evidence-access cost and the expected benefit of checking matched across conditions, a validated manipulation of anticipated effort relief is predicted to reduce verification quality. The primary outcome must use a prespecified rubric for identifying relevant evidence, methods or limitations, rather than clicks or time alone. Reduced checking is not itself an epistemic failure; secondary evidence-discrimination and decision-quality outcomes should distinguish harmful underchecking from rational effort allocation. Manipulations should be piloted, and causal analyses should retain randomised participants rather than exclude individuals on post-treatment manipulation checks. A precise null or opposite effect constrains the hypothesis in the tested context.

H2 — Narrative appeal. A higher-appeal presentation of the same proposition is predicted to reduce verification quality relative to a matched lower-appeal presentation. Factual content, length, readability and exposure to evidence should be matched or explicitly accounted for. The same prespecified quality rubric used for H1 should distinguish substantive checking from mere engagement. Increased liking alone is not confirmation, and any claim of impaired appraisal requires evidence-discrimination or decision-quality outcomes. Narrative absorption, secrecy and glamour should not be treated as one validated construct without supporting evidence.

H3 — Unsupported authority. In randomised authority conditions, an unsupported authority assertion is predicted to increase acceptance of weak-evidence claims relative to a matched neutral-source condition. The primary outcome is acceptance, measured using a prespecified scale and analysis contrast while claim content, evidence strength and access are held constant. A transparent-expertise condition should be evaluated through a separate prespecified contrast, distinguishing warranted reliance from reliance on unsupported assertions. Causal estimates should compare assigned conditions and retain randomised participants, with manipulation checks and sensitivity analyses reported separately.

H4 — Evidence discrimination. A CMF appraisal prompt is predicted to improve the prespecified contrast in responses to strongly versus weakly supported claims, compared with both no prompt and a simpler evidence-check prompt. The test requires a prompt × evidence-quality contrast, alongside measures of appropriate trust, comprehension and time cost. Evidence discrimination is not automatically discrimination between truth and falsehood. Generalised rejection is not success. If the simpler prompt performs equally well within a prespecified equivalence margin, CMF-specific advantage is not supported.

H5 — Incremental value and transfer. For one prespecified primary outcome and scoring metric, CMF measurements are predicted to improve out-of-sample prediction beyond a baseline containing prior belief, familiarity, readability and source credibility. Predictors must be available before the outcome and baseline covariates must be measured before treatment or independently; post-treatment credibility must not be treated as an unaffected baseline variable. Freeze partitions before evaluation and keep all variants of a claim within one partition. Claim-level and domain-level holdouts assess transfer to new material; participant-level holdouts are also needed when generalisation to new people is claimed. Otherwise distinctive predictive utility remains unestablished.

These hypotheses do not jointly imply a theorem. Some may be supported while others fail. Interactions should be treated as uncertain until specifically tested; the intuition that all three cues multiply each other is not itself evidence of synergy.

7. PRACTICAL APPRAISAL PROCEDURE

The practical form is a structured pause for appraising a claim and selecting a proportionate response. The following steps can be applied to communications, proposals and requests without assuming that persuasive presentation reveals whether a claim is true.

1. Specify the claim and requested action. What exactly is asserted, and what am I being asked to believe, pay, disclose, approve or forward? Separate facts from predictions and preferences.

2. Notice the pull. Does this promise relief, a flattering identity, an unusually neat story or privileged access? Record the appeal without treating it as a verdict.

3. Identify the evidential route. What observation or document would support this particular inference? Is the source relevant, independent where needed and accessible through a channel not supplied solely by the claimant?

4. State a realistic alternative and disconfirming test. What else could explain the observation? What feasible result would change the decision? A test that can only confirm the claim is weak protection.

5. Choose proportionate action. Accept provisionally, seek more evidence, defer, decline or escalate. The more irreversible the consequence, the stronger the required basis. Low-stakes claims do not justify unlimited investigation.

For example, consider an unsolicited call claiming to represent a bank or public agency. Independent contact through a verified official channel provides a route to checking the caller's assertion. A persuasive voice or knowledge of personal details is not sufficient authentication. Ending the call can be a rational boundary while identity remains uncertain. This use of the procedure concerns verification of a claimed identity, not detection of AI from a voice or attribution of wrongdoing to an organisation whose name may have been impersonated.

For an organisational proposal, a proportionate check may be a small pilot with predefined success and failure criteria, credible cost assumptions, an independent review of a critical dependency and a clear stop decision. The purpose is not to manufacture bureaucracy. A good safeguard reduces the chance of a costly error more than it costs to operate.

8. WORKED ANALYTICAL EXAMPLES

8.1 An attractive but untested procurement claim

A fictional vendor says: "Our autonomous platform will remove 80% of your administrative effort in thirty days. Leading innovators already trust it." The effort promise supplies C. An exceptional transformation story may supply M. "Leading innovators" supplies an authority cue whose evidential relevance is unclear. None of these observations determines whether the product works.

The appraisal should identify the baseline, workload mix, exception handling, integration costs, comparator, measurement window and provenance of the 80% figure. A pilot can test performance on representative tasks, with security and human review requirements maintained. If the evidence supports the claim, its convenience is a benefit. If performance remains uncertain, the rational output is a limited commitment or further test, not a numerical declaration that the pitch is fraudulent.

8.2 A compelling and well-supported warning

A specialist gives a vivid account of a safety failure and urges a simple protective measure. The communication is dramatic, offers relief and uses expert authority. A simplistic CMF score would flag it as suspicious. A properly specified appraisal instead examines the specialist's relevant competence, data, causal evidence and proportionality of the response. High appeal combined with strong support can justify action. This counterexample is

essential: the model must not penalise effective communication of true, important information.

8.3 A claim with unresolved evidence

A confidential technical project makes an extraordinary performance claim but cannot release its underlying data. Secrecy does not prove falsehood; neither does confidence substitute for the missing basis. A decision maker can record “not independently assessable,” restrict reliance and specify what evidence would change the decision. This preserves the distinction between false, unsupported and presently inaccessible.

These examples are analytical illustrations. They are not empirical case studies and provide no measured support for the model.

9. RESEARCH PROGRAMME AND VALIDATION GATES

The proposed validation programme would begin with construct elicitation and cognitive interviews, followed by independent item coding and a pilot. Confirmatory experiments would manipulate carefully matched cues while holding evidence constant within each cue comparison or crossing evidence quality explicitly as a separate factor. A separate trial would compare CMF guidance with a simple evidence prompt and an attention-matched control. External validation would use independently assessed claims, with uncertain cases retained as uncertain rather than forced into binary labels. A detailed protocol specifying materials, sampling, outcomes, analysis and stopping rules would need to be developed and preregistered before confirmatory data collection. The protocol should prespecify a smallest effect of interest, power analysis, missing-data handling, multiplicity control and intention-to-treat analyses, with diagnostic and sensitivity analyses identified separately.

A useful programme has stop criteria. If raters cannot distinguish constructs reliably, revise or abandon the scale before estimating predictive effects. If the manipulation changes readability or prior plausibility rather than the intended cue, redesign it. If the intervention raises indiscriminate distrust, do not present it as successful merely because acceptance falls. If a composite does not improve on simpler measures, do not promote unnecessary mathematical complexity.

A null result with wide uncertainty is inconclusive, not proof of no effect. A well-powered, well-executed estimate close to zero within a meaningful equivalence interval can challenge

a hypothesised effect. Both should be reported with materials, exclusions, deviations and analysis decisions. Negative results are part of completing the research, not a reason to silently alter the theory.

10. ETHICS, LIMITATIONS AND RESPONSIBLE USE

The framework can itself become a rhetorical weapon. Calling an opposing view “high mystique” or “trust me” may create the appearance of analysis while avoiding the substantive argument. Ratings should therefore be justified with observable evidence, disagreement should be recorded, and the original proposition should remain visible. The framework is not a substitute for legal, clinical, financial or technical expertise.

Authority cues vary across cultures and institutions. Differences in language fluency, disability, educational opportunity or communication style can be misread as poor credibility. Studies need accessible materials, appropriate sampling and subgroup uncertainty reporting. Any deployed aid should avoid reputational labels and provide a route to correction.

Experimental deception, where indispensable, requires prospective ethics review, minimal risk and debriefing. No participant should be exposed to real fraud, asked to disclose secrets or induced to make harmful financial decisions. Public examples should be fictional or carefully sourced and contextualised. Data collection must minimise identifying information and specify retention and access arrangements.

The present paper is limited by the absence of new observations and by the heterogeneity of the phenomena it joins. Consumer scams, scientific uncertainty, workplace proposals and political communication are not interchangeable domains. The proposed constructs may overlap with established measures and may add no explanatory value. Causal links may reverse: confidence in a claim can make it feel convenient rather than convenience causing confidence. Selective exposure can also determine which claims are encountered before any appraisal occurs. CMF does not currently detect lies, establish intent, calculate a probability of falsehood or predict organisational collapse. Any stronger empirical claim would require a specified study, population, outcome and uncertainty estimate.

Finally, a framework that encourages scrutiny can impose costs on people already overloaded. Its practical success must include time, comprehension and appropriate trust,

not just reduced endorsement. A shorter evidence prompt may ultimately be better. The research programme is designed to allow that result.

11. CONCLUSION

CMF offers a serious question rather than an established answer: when do comfort, narrative appeal and unsupported authority displace evidence-sensitive judgment, and what proportionate practice helps? This proposition is worth investigating because it names a familiar decision problem. Its legitimacy as a research proposal rests on clear constructs, independent evidence and falsifiable tests.

The defensible present output is a conceptual framework, a practical appraisal procedure and a proposed validation programme requiring ethics review, piloting, power analysis and preregistration before recruitment. A universal detector of falsehood, a validated risk score and a proven theory of social propagation remain unsupported. The framework should advance only to the extent that transparent research shows it improves understanding or decisions beyond simpler alternatives.

AUTHORSHIP AND DEVELOPMENT STATEMENT

Max Barrass, MISM is the author. This working paper was developed with AI-assisted research, drafting and critical analysis. Editorial checks addressed internal consistency, terminology, mathematical notation, proposed study design and document rendering. Bibliographic details and cited claims were checked against accessible publisher, author and indexing records; this did not constitute a full-text review of every source. These checks are not external scholarly peer review or empirical validation. No institutional affiliation, research ethics approval or completed participant study is claimed. Final scholarly responsibility and decisions about public dissemination remain with the author.

REFERENCES

Alter, A. L., & Oppenheimer, D. M. (2009). Uniting the tribes of fluency to form a metacognitive nation. *Personality and Social Psychology Review, 13*(3), 219–235. https://doi.org/10.1177/1088868309341564

Boudry, M., & Braeckman, J. (2012). How convenient! The epistemic rationale of self-validating belief systems. *Philosophical Psychology, 25*(3), 341–364. https://doi.org/10.1080/09515089.2011.579420

Frankfurt, H. G. (2005). *On bullshit*. Princeton University Press.

Green, M. C., & Brock, T. C. (2000). The role of transportation in the persuasiveness of public narratives. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 79*(5), 701–721. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.5.701

Hassan, A., & Barber, S. J. (2021). The effects of repetition frequency on the illusory truth effect. *Cognitive Research: Principles and Implications, 6*, Article 38. https://doi.org/10.1186/s41235-021-00301-5

Hoogeveen, S., Haaf, J. M., Bulbulia, J. A., Ross, R. M., McKay, R., Altay, S., Bendixen, T., Berniūnas, R., Cheshin, A., Gentili, C., Georgescu, R., Gervais, W. M., Hagel, K., Kavanagh, C., Levy, N., Neely, A., Qiu, L., Rabelo, A., Ramsay, J. E., … van Elk, M. (2022). The Einstein effect provides global evidence for scientific source credibility effects and the influence of religiosity. *Nature Human Behaviour, 6*(4), 523–535. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-021-01273-8

Kool, W., McGuire, J. T., Rosen, Z. B., & Botvinick, M. M. (2010). Decision making and the avoidance of cognitive demand. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 139*(4), 665–682. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0020198

Kunda, Z. (1990). The case for motivated reasoning. *Psychological Bulletin, 108*(3), 480–498. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.108.3.480

Littrell, S., Meyers, E. A., & Fugelsang, J. A. (2024). Not all bullshit pondered is tossed: Reflection decreases receptivity to some types of misleading information but not others. *Applied Cognitive Psychology*, *38*(1), e4154. https://doi.org/10.1002/acp.4154

Pennycook, G., Cheyne, J. A., Barr, N., Koehler, D. J., & Fugelsang, J. A. (2015). On the reception and detection of pseudo-profound bullshit. *Judgment and Decision Making, 10*(6), 549–563. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1930297500006999

Pennycook, G., Epstein, Z., Mosleh, M., Arechar, A. A., Eckles, D., & Rand, D. G. (2021). Shifting attention to accuracy can reduce misinformation online. *Nature, 592*, 590–595. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-021-03344-2

Petty, R. E., Cacioppo, J. T., & Goldman, R. (1981). Personal involvement as a determinant of argument-based persuasion. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 41*(5), 847–855. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.41.5.847

Sperber, D., Clément, F., Heintz, C., Mascaro, O., Mercier, H., Origgi, G., & Wilson, D. (2010). Epistemic vigilance. *Mind & Language, 25*(4), 359–393. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-0017.2010.01394.x